Poison in the form of a *brāhman's* wrath is even more deadly than that of a black serpent, because there is no remedy for it (XIII. 159, 33).

The Vana-parva of the *Mahābhārata* declares, "Great is the anger of the great-souled ones, and great is also their favor. It was the wrath of a *brāhmana* that made the waters of the ocean salt. Fire in the form of the wrath of the sages of the Dandaka forest is still burning and does not die out. Much is heard about the powers of such great *brāhmanas*" (III. 197, 24-27).

Once the daughter of King Trṇabindu accidently entered the hermitage of a sage and thereupon became a prey to his curse. Returning to her father, she reported the physical change she had undergone. Her father approached the sage immediately and requested him to marry the girl. He did so gladly, and later a son was born.

We find Yudhisthira cursing his mother because of the ill treatment she gave to Karna. "From now onward, no woman will be able to keep a secret" (XII. 6, 10).

Miraculous powers and the ability to curse were the two weapons that the *brāhmans* utilized so frequently.

Curses are flung at simple actions, even those done unknowingly. This is apparent from the instances of Dasaratha, who is cursed for his unintentional murder of Sravana; Karna, who is cursed for unknowingly killing a cow; and Pandu, who is cursed for killing a sage in the disguise of a deer.

Visvamitra, who by a severe penance tried to become a *brāhman*, lamented his short temper when he cursed the apsara Rambha sent by Indra to guide him.[4]

The *brāhman* Kausika repents his rash action of burning a bird to ashes because of anger (III. 197, 5-6, 31-42).

We come across numerous incidents in the *Mahābhārata* describing cases of various sages ejaculating their semen at the sight of beautiful damsels or *apsaras*. The seed, being that of a mighty king or of a refulgent sage, never goes to waste; it is reared somehow and a great sage, a strong hero, or sometimes a very beautiful maiden, is born from it.

How can these rather astounding activities be explained or made compatible with what one might expect of gods and sages? Are these actions in violation of rules which should be followed, or are they to be looked at as transcending the whole realm of moral rules? Are they to be looked upon as "legitimate" actions of persons possessed of supernatural powers, or are they to be interpreted as the actions of persons who misuse these powers or who have sunk back into the realm of ordinary human beings with all